

## NEGATIVE DOUBLES

### ABOUT THE DEALS

You will always be in the South position. Either you or partner may open the bidding.

(Strictly speaking a Negative Double is a **CALL**, not a bid, so the term is used loosely here.)

### NEGATIVE DOUBLE SUMMARY

Back in the 1950s the Roth-Stone pair introduced a convention called Sputnik, later changed to Negative Double. It is basically a Takeout Double, but applied by the partner of the opening bidder after the next opponent has overcalled. An example will clarify those messy words.

Suppose you hold this hand and partner opens 1♦.

With 8 points and a 4-card Major suit you will obviously respond 1♥.

|             |              |             |              |
|-------------|--------------|-------------|--------------|
| ♠ 9 8 3     | ♥ K Q 9 5    | ♦ 8 4       | ♣ K 6 5 3    |
| <b>WEST</b> | <b>NORTH</b> | <b>EAST</b> | <b>SOUTH</b> |
|             | 1♦           | pass        | 1♥           |

But what if your Right Hand Opponent overcalls 1♠?

|             |              |             |              |
|-------------|--------------|-------------|--------------|
| ♠ 9 8 3     | ♥ K Q 9 5    | ♦ 8 4       | ♣ K 6 5 3    |
| <b>WEST</b> | <b>NORTH</b> | <b>EAST</b> | <b>SOUTH</b> |
|             | 1♦           | 1♠          | ??           |

You have a problem.

You cannot bid ♥s (or ♣s) at the 2-level with only 8 points.

You cannot bid 1NT with no ♠ stopper.

You cannot support partner's ♦s with only a doubleton.

You hate to pass with this good a hand.

So you make a Negative Double which says:

"Partner, I would have bid 1♥ if it hadn't been for that stinking overcall."

It is necessary that you and partner agree on when a double is a Negative Double, and when it is a Penalty Double. There is no universal agreement on this but a good suggestion is to play it the same as you do for Takeout Doubles. In other words if your upper limit for Takeout Doubles is 3♠, use the same upper limit for your Negative Doubles. Many pairs these days play that doubles of game bids are for Penalty, doubles of partscores are Negative.

But just because you use Negative Doubles up to the 3♠ level certainly doesn't mean you should do so with a hand like the example above. If you are going to force partner to bid at a higher level you naturally need a stronger hand.

| STRENGTH REQUIREMENTS FOR NEGATIVE DOUBLE |                           |
|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| 6+ points*                                | Double a 1-level overcall |
| 10+ points*                               | Double a 2-level overcall |
| 12+ points*                               | Double a 3-level overcall |

\*Since Negative Doubles are forcing there is no upper limit to strength.

*Actually there is one situation when Negative Doubles are not forcing. If Opener wants to convert the double to a Penalty Double he may pass. Typically this would be a hand which is strong in the overcaller's suit and weak in the suits partner's Negative Double has suggested. It's like the partner of a Takeout Doubler passing for penalties.*

A double is a Negative Double only if Partner opens 1 of a suit and the next opponent overcalls in a suit.

Notice particularly that if there is a 1NT overcall an immediate double would **NOT** be Negative, it would be for penalties.

Notice also that if Partner has opened 1NT and RHO overcalls a suit we say that Negative Doubles do not apply. This is not universally agreed, some would say that Negative Doubles apply in this case. We will take our usual method of avoiding any controversy by making sure there are no 1NT examples included!

Now let's get to the interesting parts - the kind of hands where you would use a Negative Double. As with much of the material on competitive bidding the guidelines used vary from partnership to partnership. However, you will not go wrong by agreeing with your partner to use these.

| DISTRIBUTIONAL GUIDELINES FOR A NEGATIVE DOUBLE      |                                                        |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| If there is 1 unbid Major                            | Double promises at least 4 cards in the other Major    |
| If there are 2 unbid Majors                          | Double promises at least 4 cards in <b>ONE</b> Major   |
| Exception to above.<br>If the bidding starts 1♣ - 1♦ | Double promises at least 4 cards in <b>BOTH</b> Majors |
| If both Majors have been bid                         | Double promises at least 4 cards in both Minors        |

Now a few examples to applying the guidelines.

♠ 7 4   ♥ A J 9 5   ♦ 6 5   ♣ Q 8 6 5 3  
**WEST   NORTH   EAST   SOUTH**  
           1♦        1♠    double

With 8 points and 4 ♥s a Negative Double at the 1-level is fine.

♠ 7 4   ♥ A Q 9 5   ♦ 6 5   ♣ A 8 6 5 3

**WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH**

1♠ 2♦ double

You need at least 10 points for a Negative Double at the 2-level.

♠ Q 8 7 4 ♥ A Q 9 5 ♦ 6 5 ♣ 9 8 6

**WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH**

1♣ 1♦ double

After this specific auction you need at least 4 of both Majors.

♠ Q 8 7 4 ♥ A Q 5 ♦ 6 5 ♣ 9 8 6 3

**WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH**

1♣ 1♦ 1♠

Compare this with the previous example.

You can't double without both Majors so you just bid your 4-card Major.

♠ A J 7 ♥ A Q 5 3 ♦ 9 8 6 5 ♣ 6 3

**WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH**

1♦ 2♣ double

Double only promises 4+ cards in one Major with this auction.

However, you need some extra strength because of the 2-level.

It is also best to have some ♦s for a back-up if needed.

♠ A 8 7 4 ♥ A Q 5 ♦ 9 6 5 ♣ 9 7 6

**WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH**

1♣ 1♥ double

Although you could bid ♠s at the 1-level you should still double.

But look at the next example.

♠ A 9 8 7 4 ♥ A Q 5 ♦ 9 6 ♣ 9 7 6

**WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH**

1♣ 1♥ 1♠

This hand is very similar to the last, but here you bid 1♠.

In this way you differentiate between a 5-card and 4-card ♠ suit.

It would be worth your while to study these two examples.

♠ 4 ♥ A 10 9 8 5 ♦ A 9 6 4 ♣ Q 7 6

**WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH**

1♣ 2♠ double

You may double with a 5-card Major if you aren't strong enough to bid the suit at the level you find yourself.

**Opener's Second Bid:**

Since the 1-of-a-suit Opener has 13-21 points it is convenient to consider his strength as:

- Minimum: 13-15
- Medium: 16-18
- Maximum: 19-21

Opener should make an attempt to bid a suit indicated by the Negative Doubler, particularly if he has a 4-card Major.

If opener has a Minimum (13-15) hand, he makes a minimum rebid.

♠ A 3   ♥ K J 6 5   ♦ 9 6 4   ♣ K Q 7 6

**WEST   NORTH   EAST   SOUTH**

1♣   1♠   double

pass   2♥

You are not Reversing, you are merely supporting partner's ♥.

♠ A J 9 3   ♥ 6 5   ♦ K 6 4   ♣ K Q 7 6

**WEST   NORTH   EAST   SOUTH**

1♣   1♠   double

pass   1NT

You cannot support ♥s, but with ♠s stopped you can bid 1NT.

♠ 9 5   ♥ 6 5   ♦ Q 6 4   ♣ A K Q 7 6 4

**WEST   NORTH   EAST   SOUTH**

1♣   1♠   double

pass   2♣

Or you can rebid your original suit.

If Opener has an Medium hand, (16-18 points), he should make a jump rebid.

♠ A 3   ♥ K J 6 5   ♦ A 6 4   ♣ K Q 7 6

**WEST   NORTH   EAST   SOUTH**

1♣   1♠   double

pass   3♥

The jump shows 4 ♥ and 16-18 points.

♠ A Q 10 3   ♥ K 7   ♦ K 10 4   ♣ K Q 7 6

**WEST   NORTH   EAST   SOUTH**

1♣   1♠   double

pass   2NT

The jump to 2NT shows ♠ stoppers and 16-18 points.

When Opener has a Maximum hand, (19-21 points), he cue-bids the overcalled suit or bids game.

♠ A 3   ♥ K Q 6 5   ♦ A 6 4   ♣ A K 7 6

**WEST   NORTH   EAST   SOUTH**

1♣   1♠   double

pass   2♠

The cue-bid is forcing to game. It does not guarantee support for partner, your next bid will clear that up.

Further bidding by Responder and Opener is natural.

20 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Lead: ♣K

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 1♠

Declarer: East

Lead: ♥J

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: South

Lead: ♦K

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 1NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♠Q

Board: 5

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 2♦

Declarer: North

Lead: ♠K

Board: 6

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♦5

**Board 1**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K J 9 4  
 ♥ 10 5 3 2  
 ♦ 8 7 2  
 ♣ 6 5

♠ A 5

♥ K J 9 4

♦ A Q 10 5 4

♣ 4 3



♠ 10 8 3

♥ 6

♦ J 9 3

♣ A K Q J 9 7

♠ Q 7 6 2

♥ A Q 8 7

♦ K 6

♣ 10 8 2

*West**North**East**South*

1 ♦

2 ♣

Dbl

Pass

2 ♥

Pass

3 ♥

Pass

4 ♥

All Pass

4 ♥ by North

Lead: ♣K

The bidding has been as shown.

Partner's double promises 4 cards in at least one of the Majors. You certainly hope it is ♥s. You bid 2 ♥ and partner raises to 3 ♥.

Once partner confirms he has the ♥s you can revalue your hand to 17 points. This gives you enough extra to accept partner's invitation. You bid 4 ♥.

**Board 2**

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 8 7 5  
♥ A K 6 4  
♦ 9 7 4  
♣ 3 2

♠ Q 6 2

♥ 10 9 7 2

♦ A K 10

♣ Q J 7



♠ K J 9 3

♥ Q 8 3

♦ 8 3

♣ A K 6 4

♠ A 4

♥ J 5

♦ Q J 6 5 2

♣ 10 9 8 5

*West**North**East**South*

1 ♣

1 ♦

Dbl

Pass

1 ♠

All Pass

1 ♠ by East

Lead: ♥ J

The bidding has been as shown.

You have the special hand, 4-4 in the Majors, so you make a Negative Double. Partner replies 1 ♠.

Partner has a minimum opener with 4 ♠ s. You have a minimum response with 4 ♠ s. Pass and be grateful the opponents aren't bidding.

**Board 3**

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A 6

♥ 10 9 5

♦ A K Q J 8 7

♣ 7 2

♠ Q J 7 3

♥ Q J

♦ 9 6 5

♣ K Q 8 4



♠ 5 4 2

♥ 8 3 2

♦ 10 3 2

♣ J 10 5 3

♠ K 10 9 8

♥ A K 7 6 4

♦ 4

♣ A 9 6

The bidding has been as shown.

Sometimes using Negative Doubles seems like you can read minds. You know for sure that partner has 4 ♠s since that is the only unbid Major. You know for sure that partner has 10+ points because he made a Negative Double of a 2-level overcall. So you conclude that your side has 8 ♠s and 27+ points . . . . . and you bid 4 ♠.

*West**North**East**South*

2 ♦

Dbl

Pass

1 ♥

4 ♠

All Pass

4 ♠ by South

Lead: ♦ K

**Board 4**

West Deals

Both Vul

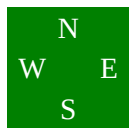
♠ 8 6  
 ♥ Q 9 7 5  
 ♦ K Q 10  
 ♣ A Q J 5

♠ Q J

♥ K 4 3

♦ A J 8 7 5

♣ K 7 2



♠ K 10 9 4

♥ A J 8

♦ 9 3 2

♣ 10 9 6

♠ A 7 5 3 2

♥ 10 6 2

♦ 6 4

♣ 8 4 3

*West*

1 ♣

1NT

All Pass

1NT by West

Lead: ♠ Q

*North*

1 ♦

*East*

1 ♠

*South*

Pass

The bidding has been as shown.

The general guideline for a Negative Double when both Majors are unbid is that you must have 4+ cards in at least **ONE** of the Majors. But for this specific sequence, 1 ♣ - 1 ♦, you do not double unless you have **BOTH** Majors. When you have only one of them you just bid it. Like this hand. You bid 1 ♠. Partner rebids 1NT.

Partner has a minimum hand and fewer than 4 ♠s. A good time for you to pass.

**Board 5**

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 8  
♥ A K 7 6 4  
♦ Q J 10 8 4  
♣ A 8

♠ J 10 6 4

♥ Q

♦ A K 9 6 5 2

♣ K 10

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ A K Q 5

♥ 5 3

♦ 7 3

♣ J 9 6 3 2

♠ 9 7 3 2

♥ J 10 9 8 2

♦ —

♣ Q 7 5 4

*West*

1 ♥

*North*

2 ♦

*East*

Dbl

*South*

All Pass

2 ♦ by North

Lead: ♠ K

The bidding has been as shown.

Partner has 10+ points, a ♠ suit and fewer than 3 ♥s. Doesn't this look like the perfect hand to pass for penalties? Yes.

**Board 6**

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A 10 9 6

♥ K Q J 6

♦ 9 3 2

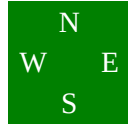
♣ K 8

♠ J 5 4 3 2

♥ A 8 2

♦ J 6

♣ 7 6 4



♠ K 8 7

♥ 10 5 3

♦ A Q 10

♣ A 10 9 3

♠ Q

♥ 9 7 4

♦ K 8 7 5 4

♣ Q J 5 2

*West**North**East**South*

1♣

1♦

Dbl

Pass

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♦5

The bidding has been as shown.

This is one of the nicer parts of Negative Doubles. When the bidding is 1♣ - 1♦, a double by you promises both Majors. It's like you are allowed to bid both suits at once, 1♠♥. So you double and partner says 1NT.

Partner doesn't have 4 of either Major. But he does have 13 points and ♦s stopped. You also have 13 points so you bid 3NT.